

Chapter 130-4

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On the way back, Xiao Bai was chattering away like a magpie.

From her mouth, one could constantly hear comments from online.

Most were lamenting Liang Shi's retirement from the industry, though many also expressed their blessings.

There was even a bold artist who directly rode Liang Shi's wave to officially announce her relationship with a same-sex partner.

Liang Shi used her account that hadn't been deactivated yet to comment on and like her post.

Then she chose to deactivate the account.

She also sent a message to that artist on WeChat: [Wishing you forever and always.]¹

The weather was beautiful. The sun shone warmly on the earth, making people feel lazy.

The peach blossoms outside had just bloomed, clustered on the branches, a sight that lifted one's spirits.

After getting out of the car, Liang Shi planned to go home, but she ran into Qi Jiao at the entrance of the residential complex.

Qi Jiao had both hands behind her back. When she saw Liang Shi, she smiled and walked over.

"Congratulations on becoming an ordinary person again." Qi Jiao said as she brought out a bunch of irises from behind her back.

The flower language of irises is freedom.

Qi Jiao said: "I saw what you said online. Thank you for speaking up for our community."

Liang Shi:

Qi Jiao smiled slightly. "Actually... I also like girls."

"But don't misunderstand. I'm not giving you flowers because I like you. It's also not..." Qi Jiao was momentarily at a loss for words. After a long while, she knocked on her own head and said: "This wooden head of mine. It's just... I've always seen you as a younger sister."

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "Is that so?"

Qi Jiao nodded: "Of course. Although I like girls, I... haven't dated yet. My family is actually quite open-minded. They think as long as I'm happy, that's fine. But from childhood until now, it's always been boys chasing me. I find them scary to look at."

Liang Shi and Qi Jiao stood by the roadside and chatted for a while. Then they heard someone calling Qi Jiao's name.

The two of them turned around together and saw a married couple walking toward them, along with a slightly roguish-looking man and a woman dressed in a professional elite style.

Qi Jiao immediately beamed with joy and practically jogged over. "Dad, Mom, Gē, Jiě!"

Liang Shi watched their family standing together and felt quite gratified.

At noon, she even had a meal with Qi Jiao's family. Probably because Qi Jiao's whole family knew about Qi Jiao's orientation, the looks they gave Liang Shi weren't very friendly—despite Qi Jiao's repeated insistence that Liang Shi was just an ordinary friend.

Liang Shi still ended up being made to drink quite a bit of alcohol.

In the afternoon, back at home, she scrolled through the comments online. They were mixed—some praising, some criticizing.

As evening approached, the city started raining again.

The irises Qi Jiao gave her were placed in a vase. The peach blossoms Liang Shi had picked on her way back in the afternoon lay quietly on the coffee table.

Liang Shi curled up on the sofa watching TV—an old movie she had seen many times.

The pitter-patter of rain fell on the windows, connecting into streaks of water.

This house used to be the place she found most comfortable. No matter how noisy it was outside, she could build a warm little world by herself.

But now the house felt very empty.

Even with the movie playing, it still felt quiet.

Liang Shi took out a piece of paper again to sort through those clues.

She and the original owner had been artificially swapped, so their previous swap was a correction—a restoration of order. The trigger was that she was down on her luck here, while the original owner wanted to harm others over there.

Qi Jiao was kind by nature but lived a painful life, so it was equivalent to giving her a chance at rebirth.

As for Sun Chengcheng, she had gained the ability to travel back and forth. She couldn't stay in utopia forever.

She still had to spend most of her time here, and here caused her pain.

What allowed her to temporarily escape from the pain was the other world. But without comparison, there's no harm—the beauty of the other world made her only want to indulge in it. So in the real world, she became increasingly depressed, living an exceptionally miserable life.

Just like what Liang Shi saw when she went there that day.

—So this was very likely some kind of balancing mechanism.

Liang Shi felt like she had figured out some clues. Suddenly, her mind felt like it was being pricked by needles, and a strange crackling sound of static came through: "Crackle crackle..."

Liang Shi pressed on her temples. Those static sounds mixed with strange mechanical tones kept coming through.

[Connecting... crackle...]

[Repairing... crackle... repair in progress... crackle...]

A few seconds later, her mind returned to calm. The mechanical voice unique to that damned system came through: [Phew! Finally fixed! Sorry, Host. Due to atmospheric interference that day causing space-time disruption, the program was damaged, resulting in a deviation during transmission.]

[But Host, you're really smart~ You actually figured out the balancing mechanism of the plane worlds. Applause for you.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Facing the system, Liang Shi had only four words: "Send me back."

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1. Wishing you forever and always (祝久久): A blessing playing on the word "久" (jiǔ), which means "long/forever" and sounds like the number nine (九). "久久" literally means "for a long, long time" and is commonly used in blessings to wish someone lasting happiness, especially in relationships. ⇐